The Geography of Armed Conflict in Nigeria

A State-Level Spatial Analysis of Political Violence, 2020–2025
Results report • 9 November 2026 • 37 states • source: ACLED via HDX

This report maps and analyses armed conflict across all 36 states and the FCT using ACLED event data (1997–2026). Unlike a fear study, every variable here is **objective and state-complete** — there are no coverage gaps. It measures conflict **intensity** (deaths and events per capita), **character** (who is targeted), **escalation** (change over time), and **spatial clustering** (whether violence forms contiguous belts).

Data note.

"Political violence" = ACLED battles + violence against civilians + explosions/remote violence + mob violence. Rates use NBS 2023 projected population. Annual comparisons exclude 2026 (partial year). State aggregates only, per ACLED's Terms of Use.

1. A record year, and a moving epicentre

National political-violence deaths reached **15,771 in 2025** — the deadliest year on record, above the 2014–15 Boko Haram peak. More importantly for a *geography*, the centre of violence has **migrated from the North-East to the North-West and North-Central**.

Zone	2015 deaths	2025 deaths	Direction
North East	9,199	4,467	falling (Boko Haram past peak)
North West	745	6,297	rising 8.5× (banditry)
North Central	901	3,865	rising 4.3×
South East	41	517	rising 13× (IPOB/ESN)
South South	155	366	rising
South West	34	259	rising

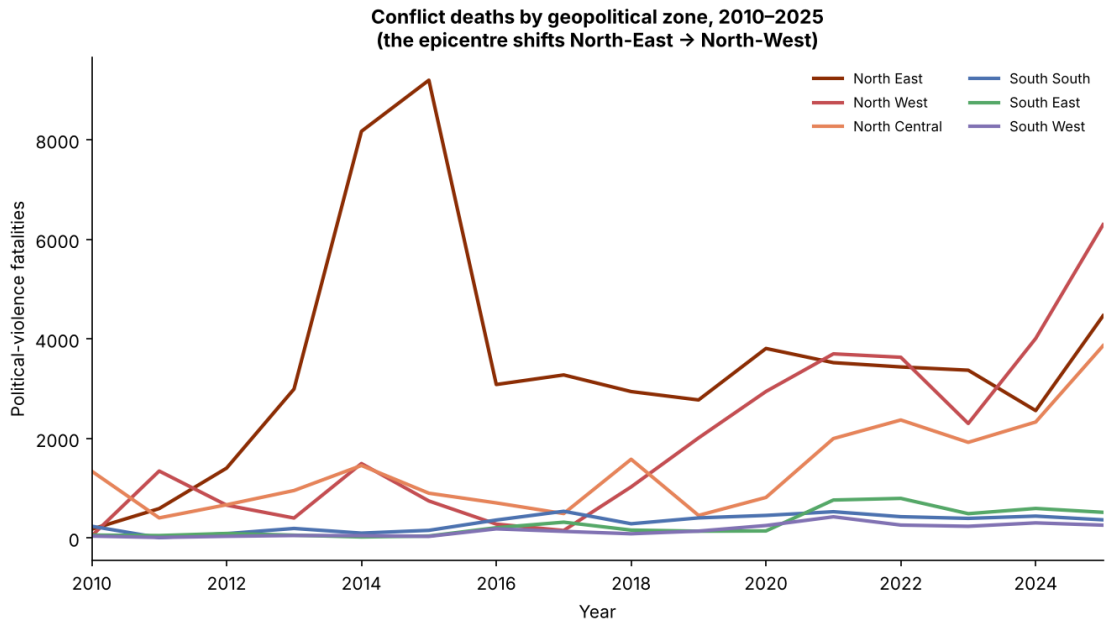


Figure 1. Conflict deaths by geopolitical zone, 2010–2025. The North-East (Boko Haram) peaks in 2014–15 then falls; the North-West (banditry) overtakes it from 2021.

2. Intensity of conflict (2020–2025)

Deaths per 100,000 concentrate sharply: **Borno 270, Zamfara 155, Niger 82, Katsina 61, Kaduna 59, Benue 48, Plateau 47, Sokoto 41** — every high-intensity state is northern.

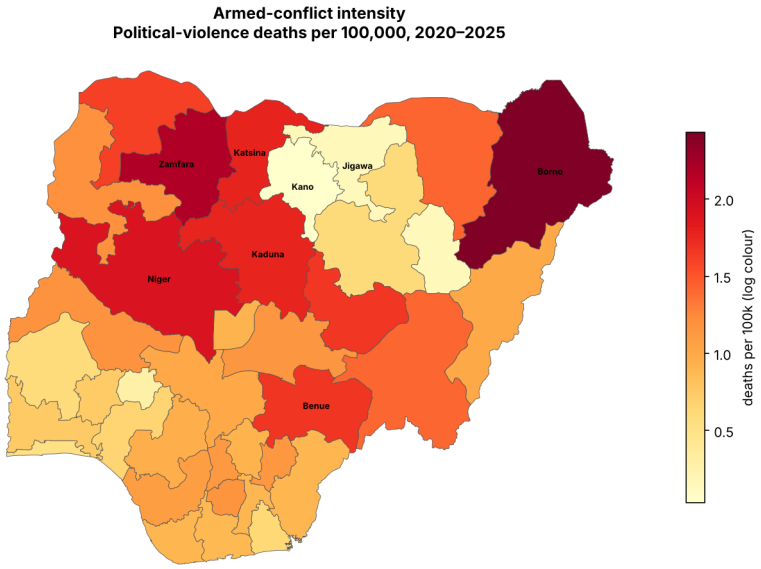


Figure 2. Armed-conflict intensity: political-violence deaths per 100,000 (log colour).

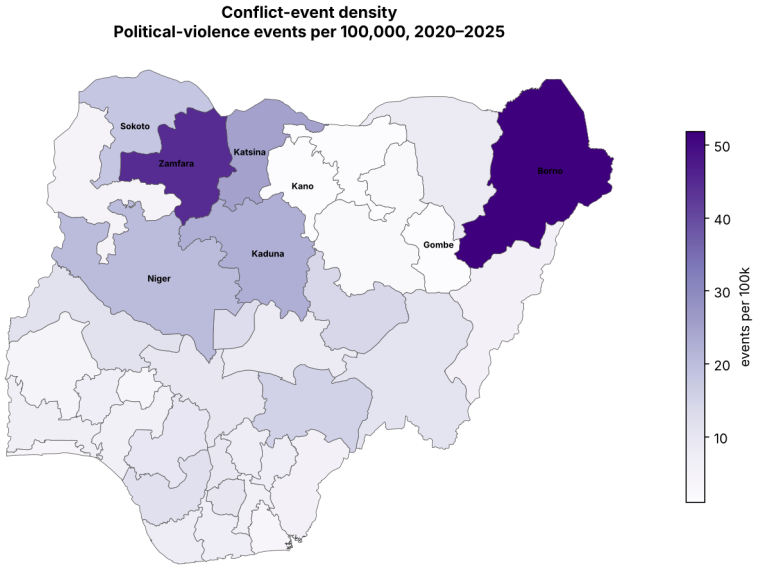


Figure 3. Conflict-event density per 100,000.

3. The character of the violence

A key distinction is **who is targeted**. In 18 states, civilians are the main victims (≥45% of deaths are violence against civilians — Plateau 78%, Benue 71%, Sokoto 60%); in 15, armed clashes/battles dominate (Borno, Zamfara, Niger); 4 are low-intensity. This separates the Middle-Belt massacre zones from the North-East/North-West battle theatres.

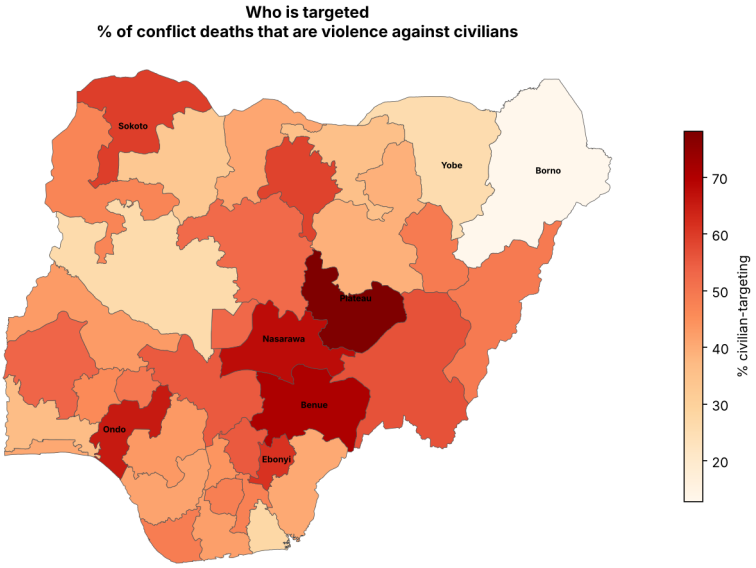


Figure 4. Share of conflict deaths that are violence against civilians (%).

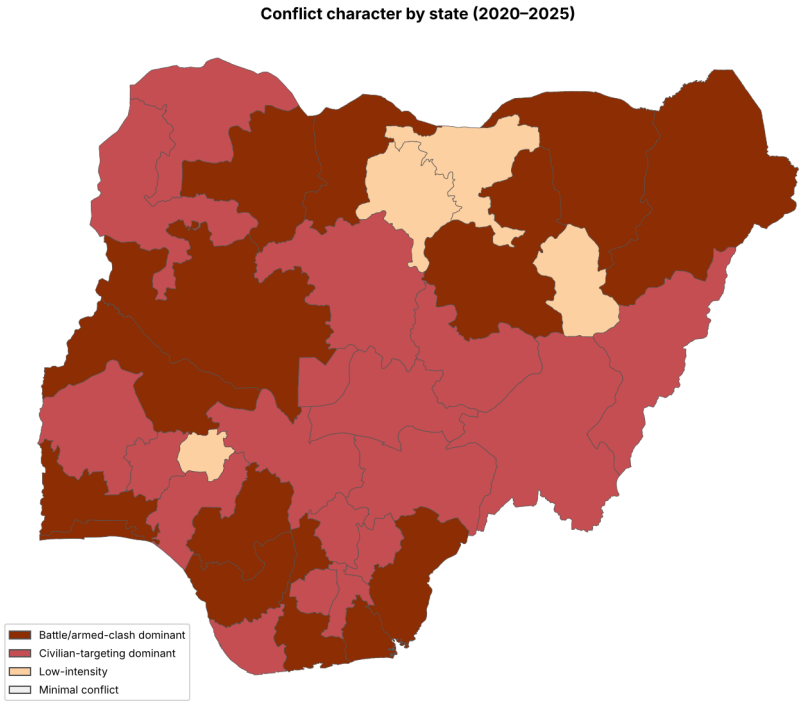


Figure 5. Dominant conflict character by state.

4. Escalation 2014–19 → 2020–25

Ratio of conflict deaths between the two periods identifies the growth fronts.

State	Zone	2014–19	2020–25	Ratio
Kebbi	North West	40	958	24×
Niger	North Central	267	5,506	21×
Kwara	North Central	39	640	16×
Sokoto	North West	206	2,514	12×
Imo	South East	88	899	10×
Katsina	North West	649	5,672	9×
Oyo	South West	33	295	9×

The **North-West/North-Central banditry corridor** and the **South-East** are the escalation fronts. Borno is the only major theatre in decline (0.78×).

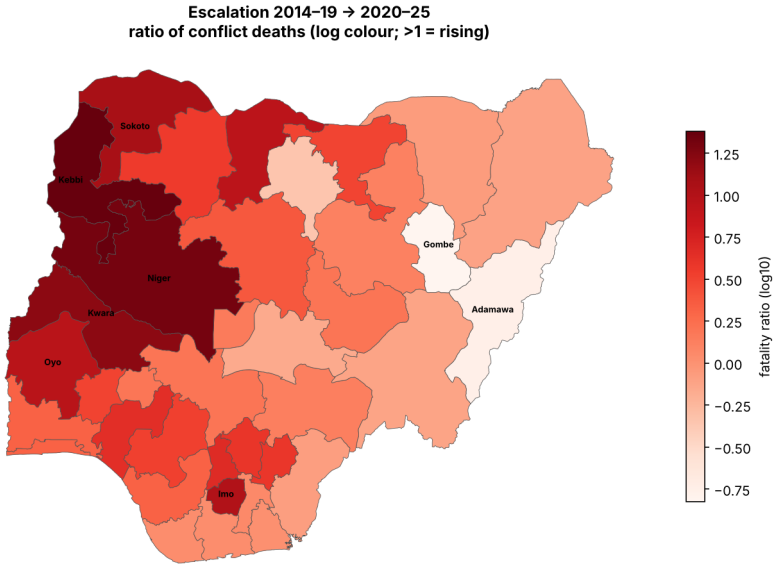


Figure 6. Escalation ratio, 2014–19 → 2020–25 (log colour; darker = faster growth).

5. Is conflict spatially clustered?

A global **Moran's I = 0.187 (p = 0.033**, queen contiguity, log fatality rate, 999 permutations) confirms conflict is **significantly spatially clustered** — it forms contiguous belts rather than scattering randomly, so a state's risk is bound up with its neighbours'. Local indicators (LISA) locate the clusters:

Cluster	States
High–High (hot)	Kaduna, Katsina, Kebbi, Niger, Nasarawa, Ebonyi
Low–Low (cold)	Abia, Akwa Ibom, Bayelsa, Edo, Ekiti, Osun, Ogun, Lagos …

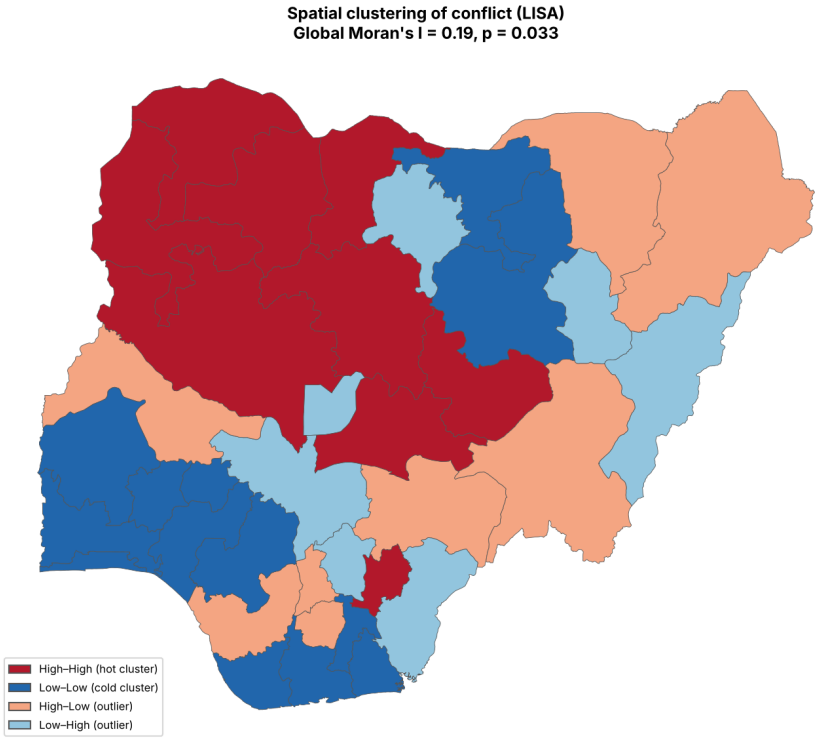


Figure 7. LISA clusters. The North-West/North-Central forms a contiguous hot cluster; the south is a cold cluster.

Interpretation & next steps

The spatial statistics support a **diffusion/spillover** reading of Nigerian insecurity: banditry has spread as a contiguous corridor across the North-West into North-Central, while the old North-East theatre contracts. For publication, add FDR-adjusted local Moran p-values, and (with an ACLED actor-level export) decompose by perpetrator (bandits vs jihadists vs separatists).

Sources

ACLED © Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (state-level aggregates only, per Terms of Use), HDX dataset "Nigeria – Conflict Events". Boundaries: OCHA/HDX cod-ab-nga. Population: NBS / National Population Commission. Compiled 9 November 2026.